

An Epidemic of Selfie Deaths

OUTSIDE MAGAZINE PUBLISHED a discussion on the “epidemic of selfie deaths.”¹³⁴ This “epidemic”—a loss of 259 lives between 2011 and 2017—is another example of denominator blindness.

In 2015, there were 12 “selfie deaths”; there were also 737 Americans who died falling out of bed.¹³⁵ Selfie deaths got all of the media coverage.

The epidemic described by *Outside* magazine over those eight years averaged 43 deaths annually. That’s the numerator. What of the denominator? To figure that out, we need to come up with a credible estimate for the number of selfies taken each year.

Google’s I/O developer conference in 2014 gave us a partial answer: Android users take an average of 93 million selfies *every day*.¹³⁶ That was a decade and a few billion smartphone sales ago. Now add in iPhone users, and we get about 200 million daily selfies. Each year, that’s about 75 billion selfies versus 43 deaths. The odds of a selfie death are about 1.7 billion to one.

This is another example of ignoring the mundane while focusing on the exciting. Common deaths like heart disease or cancer are high-probability eventualities, but they generate far less emotional response than the extremely rare low-probability events like terrorism.

In 2023, not a single person died in a commercial flight in the US, but there were more than 36,000 traffic fatalities. Whether you are flying for business or pleasure, the cab ride to the airport is likely to be the most dangerous part of your trip.

Statistically speaking, you should be far more concerned with your LDL cholesterol and high blood pressure than you should with shark attacks, selfie deaths, or terrorism. Cancer and heart disease account for nearly half of annual deaths in the United States. Not that you could tell by media